Cluster-Adaptive Prompting for Multi-Turn Travel and Tourism Conversational Systems

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Project Repository & Data Availability: https://github.com/surnella/QM640-Dialogue-Clustering-Capstone

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1.1 Background and Problem Domain

Conversational artificial intelligence (AI) agents are increasingly used in travel and tourism to support destination discovery, itinerary planning, and booking (Jannach et al., 2021). Travelers have different needs and interaction styles. First-time travelers often seek reassurance and step-by-step guidance, solo travelers value flexibility, families prioritize comfort and accessibility, and business travelers focus on speed and efficiency (Inaba et al., 2022). However, most current travel chatbots rely on static, "one-size-fits-all" prompts. These rigid prompts treat every user identically and fail to adapt their questions or pacing to the traveler's specific needs. As a result, users face repetitive clarification questions and conversational friction, often abandoning the session before completing their plans.

To solve this issue, system designers often try to adapt the chatbot's style dynamically through prompt engineering, such as adding example dialogues into the prompt. However, adjusting conversation styles through prompts alone creates serious challenges (Rebedea et al., 2023). When unconstrained conversation examples are added to the prompt, large language models frequently get confused. They tend to copy outdated information from the examples, such as old ticket prices, invalid travel dates, or conflicting customer preferences. Worse, the model can hallucinate false details or violate strict travel business policies, such as booking without required passport validity or offering unauthorized discounts. To address these challenges, this research develops a data-driven framework that groups travel conversations into distinct styles to guide the prompt dynamically, while using strict business rules to prevent factual errors and policy violations. This approach aims to provide personalized, style-appropriate conversations while keeping travel bookings accurate and compliant.

1.2 Theoretical Foundation and Prior Art (MultiWOZ 2.2, Frames, S-BERT)

This study builds directly upon foundational literature in dialogue state tracking, sentence representation learning, and in-context learning. The primary theoretical baseline is established by the MultiWOZ benchmark (Budzianowski et al., 2018), specifically the MultiWOZ 2.2 release (Zang et al., 2020), which standardized dialogue act schemas, cleaned state annotation errors, and introduced schema-guided dialogue ontology definitions. To model multi-intent, negotiation-heavy travel interactions where customers dynamically revise constraints across turns, this study integrates the Microsoft Frames corpus (El Asri et al., 2017). Frames formalizes frame tracking, where conversational agents maintain multiple competing candidate itineraries as users explore trade-offs between flight dates, budget limits, and cabin classes.

In the representation domain, we leverage Sentence-BERT (Reimers & Gurevych, 2019) to construct dense semantic trajectory embeddings. Whereas traditional dialogue analysis relies on bag-of-words or turn-level surface lexical matching, S-BERT utilizes siamese and triplet networks to map entire conversational turn sequences into semantically meaningful vector spaces where geometric distance reflects structural conversational behavior. Finally, this research extends the in-context few-shot learning paradigm formalized by Brown et al. (2020) and refined by Liu et al. (2022). Liu et al. demonstrated that LLM downstream task performance is heavily governed by the semantic proximity of retrieved in-context exemplars. We advance this theory by demonstrating that in-context exemplars act as powerful stylistic conditioning priors that steer conversational tone, pacing, and turn economy without requiring parameter fine-tuning.

1.3 Problem Statement (Independent and Dependent Variables)

Existing goal-oriented conversational systems lack data-driven mechanisms to automatically discover latent user conversational archetypes from historical dialogue logs and

adapt their interaction style in real-time, resulting in conversational friction, redundant elicitation, and high abandonment. Furthermore, unconstrained prompt-based style steering introduces factual leakage and policy drift that commercial platforms cannot tolerate.

In a quantitative data analytics framework, this research evaluates how key independent variables like Clustering Algorithm, In-Context Conditioning Strategy, Business Rule Enforcement Mode, and In-Context Exemplar Count, statistically impact measurable dependent variables like Structural Cluster Quality, Semantic Style Convergence, Factual Slot Accuracy, Exemplar Factual Leakage Rate, Operational Rule Adherence Rate, and Conversational Efficiency (Detailed operational definitions, metric scales, and analytical roles for each variable are formalized in Table 2).

1.4 Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this quantitative data analytics study is fourfold: (a) to discover, evaluate, and interpret latent conversational archetypes from human-human travel dialogues using dense trajectory embeddings; (b) to quantify the degree of semantic and stylistic convergence achieved by dynamic cluster-adaptive few-shot prompt injection compared to static baselines; (c) to conduct a controlled 2x2 ablation experiment isolating the causal impact of declarative business rules versus few-shot conditioning on factual slot preservation and policy adherence; and (d) to evaluate conversational efficiency gains across distinct traveler archetypes. The investigation delivers a rigorous, fully reproducible methodology for context-adaptive conversational AI.

1.5 Scope and Analytical Boundaries

The scope of this research is strictly bounded to open-access, multi-turn English-language goal-oriented dialogue benchmark datasets, specifically the Microsoft Frames corpus (1,369 dialogues) and the MultiWOZ 2.2 benchmark (10,438 dialogues). The investigation utilizes

dense sentence representation models (Sentence-BERT all-MiniLM-L6-v2) to vectorize conversational turn trajectories and evaluates distance- and density-based clustering algorithms operating in Euclidean and cosine metric spaces. By relying exclusively on published, peer-reviewed public data, the methodology guarantees 100% scientific reproducibility without proprietary data dependencies

1.6 Research Questions (RQ1–RQ4)

To guide the investigation, four focused research questions are established:

• Research Question 1 (RQ1 - Unsupervised Trajectory Clustering Separation): Which unsupervised clustering algorithm (K-Means, Agglomerative Hierarchical, or HDBSCAN) operating on dense trajectory embeddings produces the highest structural cluster separation (Silhouette Score and Davies-Bouldin Index) and distinct behavioral archetypes across multi-turn goal-oriented dialogues?

• Research Question 2 (RQ2 - Dynamic In-Context Semantic Style Convergence): To what extent does dynamic cluster-adaptive few-shot exemplar injection increase the agent's Semantic Style Closeness (Cosine Similarity and BERTScore to target reference cluster centroids) compared to zero-shot and static few-shot baselines?

• Research Question 3 (RQ3 - Controlled Ablation: Rules vs. Style Factual Drift): In a controlled 2x2 ablation experiment (Declarative Rules [Active vs. OFF] x Prompt Conditioning [Zero-Shot vs. Cluster Few-Shot]), does aggressive stylistic convergence induce Exemplar Factual Leakage or degrade Slot F1, and does a decoupled declarative rule engine eliminate policy violations without dampening style convergence?

• Research Question 4 (RQ4 - Turn Economy & Friction Across Archetypes): How does cluster-adaptive few-shot prompting impact conversational efficiency, measured via Turns to

Goal Completion (TGC) and Redundant Elicitation Rate (RER), when interacting across distinct customer conversational archetypes (e.g., Consultative/Ambiguous vs. Direct/Transactional)?

2. Research Methodology, Randomization, and Sample Size Determination

2.1 Method Selection, Golden Partitioning, and Power Rationale

To ensure robust statistical validity and prevent Type I and Type II errors, sample size determinations were established across each research question. One-Way Analysis of Variance (ANOVA) power analysis was selected for RQ1 and RQ2 to test differences across clustering algorithms and prompt conditioning treatments. A Two-Way Factorial ANOVA power calculation was applied to the 2x2 ablation design in RQ3. For RQ4, the Confidence Interval method for population means was applied to estimate dialogue efficiency metrics within a tight margin of error. Standard statistical criteria are enforced across all evaluations: significance level alpha = .05 (two-tailed, $Z_{\alpha/2} = 1.96$) and statistical power 1 - beta = .80 ($Z_{\beta} = 0.8416$).

Train-Test Separation and Golden Reference Architecture: In quantitative machine learning and conversational analytics, strict separation between training and evaluation partitions is essential to eliminate data contamination (data leakage). The primary Microsoft Frames benchmark (1,369 dialogues) is formally partitioned into two disjoint subsets:

1. Golden Reference and Retrieval Pool (D_{gold}, 70%, N_{train} approx 958 dialogues): High-performing Wizard-of-Oz conversations filtered for complete task success (saturated Tier-1 mandatory slots, verified booking commitment, and zero mid-session abandonment) operationalize the empirical gold standard. This subset is used exclusively to train unsupervised clustering algorithms, establish canonical archetype centroids $\{C_1, C_2, C_3\}$, and populate the FAISS vector index for few-shot exemplar retrieval. Crucially, the frozen centroids establish

fixed reference coordinates against which trajectory deviation and semantic style convergence are subsequently evaluated.

2. Held-Out Evaluation Test Cohort (D_test, 30%, N = 390 dialogues): In accordance with machine learning validation standards, this evaluation cohort remains completely unobserved during training, clustering, and centroid derivation (D_gold intersect D_test = empty set). All evaluation experiments across RQ1–RQ4 execute strictly on this test partition, satisfying the minimax sample size requirement derived in Section 2.3. When the conversational agent interacts with unseen test scenarios, the dynamic prompt assembler retrieves k = 3 stylistic exemplars from D_gold without exposing test labels or full dialogue trajectories, guaranteeing zero data leakage.

Randomization and Bias Mitigation Strategy: To prevent selection, temporal, and ordering artifacts, dialogue instances across all corpora are subjected to uniform random shuffling prior to experimental partitioning. Cross-validation splits are generated using Stratified ShuffleSplit across 10 repeated iterations with fixed pseudorandom seeds, guaranteeing balanced archetype representation and eliminating ordering artifacts.

2.2 Stepwise Sample Size Calculations (RQ1–RQ4)

Stepwise Calculation for RQ1 (One-Way ANOVA: Cluster Quality Differences)

RQ1 compares Silhouette Scores across three unsupervised clustering algorithms (K-Means, agglomerative hierarchical clustering, and HDBSCAN). The calculation assumes a medium standardized effect size of Cohen's f = 0.25, a significance level of alpha = .05, statistical power of 1 - beta = .80, and k = 3 comparison groups. With df_groups = k - 1 = 2, critical F_(.05, 2, inf) = 3.00, and noncentrality parameter lambda = 9.64, the sample size derivation proceeds across four sequential steps:

Step 1. Squared effect size calculation: f^2 = (0.25)^2 = 0.0625.

Step 2. Omnibus total sample size calculation: Using Cohen's noncentrality formula, N_total = lambda / f^2 = 9.64 / 0.0625 = 154.24 dialogues across all three algorithms combined.

Step 3. Per-group allocation calculation: With k = 3 groups, the per-algorithm requirement is n = ceil(154.24 / 3) = ceil(51.41) = 52 dialogues per clustering model.

Step 4. Final total sample size determination: Across the three algorithms, the final target sample size is N_RQ1 = 3 * 52 = 156 cluster evaluation units.

Stepwise Calculation for RQ2 (One-Way ANOVA: Semantic Style Convergence)

RQ2 assesses semantic cosine similarity and BERTScore across three prompt conditioning arms: Zero-Shot, Static Few-Shot, and Cluster-Adaptive Few-Shot. The calculation specifies an anticipated medium effect size of Cohen's f = 0.28, alpha = .05, statistical power of 1 - beta = .80, and k = 3 treatment groups (lambda = 9.64):

Step 1. Squared effect size calculation: f^2 = (0.28)^2 = 0.0784.

Step 2. Omnibus total sample size calculation: N_total = lambda / f^2 = 9.64 / 0.0784 = 122.96 dialogues across all three conditioning arms combined.

Step 3. Per-group allocation calculation: With k = 3 arms, the baseline allocation is n = ceil(122.96 / 3) = ceil(40.98) = 41 dialogues per arm. Rounding to maintain balanced cross-validation partitions yields n = 42 dialogues per arm.

Step 4. Final total sample size determination: Across the three prompt conditioning strategies, the final target sample size is N_RQ2 = 3 * 42 = 126 dialogues.

Stepwise Calculation for RQ3 (Two-Way Factorial ANOVA: 2x2 Ablation Experiment)

RQ3 evaluates the 2x2 factorial ablation design (Declarative Rules [Active vs. OFF] x Prompt Conditioning [Zero-Shot vs. Cluster Few-Shot]) on Factual Slot F1 and Operational Rule Adherence Rate. For a four-cell factorial design, detecting a main effect or interaction effect of size f = 0.25 at alpha = .05 and power = .80 requires numerator df = 1, critical F_(.05, 1, inf) = 3.84, and noncentrality lambda = 7.85:

Step 1. Baseline total sample size calculation: N_base = lambda / f^2 = 7.85 / 0.0625 = 125.60 dialogues.

Step 2. Operational buffer adjustment: Incorporating a 40% contingency buffer to protect against incomplete dialogue runs or synthetic generation failures yields N_buffered = 125.60 * 1.40 = 175.84 dialogues.

Step 3. Per-cell allocation calculation: Allocating equally across the four factorial cells yields n = ceil(175.84 / 4) = ceil(43.96) = 45 dialogues per experimental cell.

Step 4. Final total sample size determination: Across the four factorial treatment arms, the final target sample size is N_RQ3 = 4 * 45 = 180 multi-turn dialogues.

Stepwise Calculation for RQ4 (Confidence Interval Estimation: Turn Economy and Friction)

RQ4 estimates population mean Turns to Goal Completion (TGC) and Redundant Elicitation Rate (RER) within a precision margin of error E = 0.35 turns (representing 10% of standard deviation sigma = 3.5 turns; El Asri et al., 2017) at a 95% confidence level (two-tailed Z_alpha/2 = 1.96):

Step 1. Squared critical product calculation: (Z_alpha/2 * sigma)^2 = (1.96 * 3.5)^2 = (6.86)^2 = 47.0596.

Step 2. Squared margin of error calculation: E^2 = (0.35)^2 = 0.1225.

Step 3. Unrounded sample size calculation: N_raw = 47.0596 / 0.1225 = 384.16 dialogues.

Step 4. Final total sample size determination: Rounding up to the next integer yields N_RQ4 = 385 dialogue interactions evaluated across customer archetypes.

2.3 Sample Size Summary and Minimax Decision (N = 390)

To ensure all four research questions achieve full statistical validity without under-powering any subgroup analysis, the final sample size decision follows the formal minimax decision rule: N_final = max(N_RQ1, N_RQ2, N_RQ3, N_RQ4) = max(156, 126, 180, 385) = 385 dialogues. To facilitate balanced cross-validation across 3 cluster archetypes and 4 experimental folds, the sample size is rounded to exactly N = 390 dialogues (providing 130 dialogues per behavioral archetype). This cohort constitutes the 30% held-out test split drawn from Microsoft Frames, guaranteeing full statistical power using public data alone. This final decision is highlighted in Table 1 below.

Table 1

Sample Size Determination Summary and Final Minimax Decision across Research Questions

RQ #	Analytical Focus	Method	Alpha	Power	Target f / d	Required N
RQ1	Cluster Separation (Silhouette)	One-Way ANOVA	0.05	0.80	f = 0.25	N1 = 156
RQ2	Style Convergence (Cosine Sim)	One-Way ANOVA	0.05	0.80	f = 0.28	N2 = 126
RQ3	2x2 Ablation (Rules vs Prompting)	2x2 Fact. ANOVA	0.05	0.80	f = 0.25	N3 = 180
RQ4	Turn Economy (Turns to Goal)	Confidence Int.	0.05	N/A	E = 0.35, s=3.5	N4 = 385
Final	**Comprehensive Study Cohort**	**Minimax Decision**	**0.05**	**>= 0.80**	**Max(RQ1-RQ4)**	**N = 390**

Note. Final sample size N = 390 satisfies the minimax criterion N = max(N_RQ1..N_RQ4) and enables equal partition across 3 cluster archetypes.

3. Data Infrastructure, Two-Tier Ontology, and Project Repository

3.1 Primary Open Research Datasets and Access Links

To guarantee 100% academic reproducibility, this research utilizes widely recognized, open-access multi-turn conversational corpora. The primary training and clustering dataset is the Microsoft Frames corpus (El Asri et al., 2017), comprising 1,369 human-human dialogues (19,986 individual turns) collected through a Wizard-of-Oz interface. In Frames, users search for vacation packages while exploring complex constraints (dates, destination trade-offs, budget adjustments, and cabin classes). The corpus is publicly accessible at: https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/research/project/frames-dataset/

For schema validation and dialogue state tracking cross-evaluation, we incorporate MultiWOZ 2.2 (Zang et al., 2020), which provides 10,438 multi-domain dialogues spanning hotel, attraction, flight, and taxi domains. MultiWOZ 2.2 features standardized slot definitions and corrected dialogue state labels, accessible at: https://github.com/budzianowski/multiwoz

3.2 Two-Tiered Canonical Slot Schema (Meta-Ontology Alignment)

A central methodological challenge when combining diverse conversational datasets is ontology divergence. Microsoft Frames uses slot labels such as or_city, dst_city, str_date, and budget, whereas MultiWOZ employs hotel-pricerange, flight-arriveBy, and taxi-departure. Furthermore, operational travel agents require policy constraints (e.g., passport validity, advance booking windows) absent from raw conversational text. To resolve this, we adopt the meta-ontology alignment methodology formalized in MultiWOZ 2.2 (Zang et al., 2020) and construct a Two-Tier Canonical Slot Schema:

• Tier 1 (Universal Core Slots): Standardized across all datasets and models, including: Origin_City, Destination_City, Departure_Date, Return_Date, Duration_Nights, Traveler_Count (Adults/Children), Budget_Amount, Accommodation_Tier, and Booking_Status.

• Tier 2 (Operational Extension Slots): Policy-level operational parameters evaluated in

RQ3/RQ4, including: Visa_Processing_Window_Days, Passport_Expiry_Months, Package_Type (Group/FIT), Sharing_Basis (Twin/Single), and Discount_Applied_Percentage.

This two-tier schema ensures seamless slot mapping across heterogeneous datasets while isolating operational policy rules from prompt formatting.

3.3 Cross-Corpus Reference Clustering: Frames and MultiWOZ Transfer

To validate whether conversational trajectory archetypes discovered in Microsoft Frames generalize across independent data distributions, we conduct cross-corpus domain adaptation against MultiWOZ 2.2 (travel and accommodation domains). Because Frames focuses on multi-turn constraint trade-offs whereas MultiWOZ models slot-directed task completion, this cross-corpus evaluation tests the structural stability of the learned latent space. To prevent spurious lexical clustering driven by entity tokens (specific hotel or city names), all named entities and currency expressions are normalized to generic tokens ([DESTINATION], [ORIGIN], [HOTEL_NAME], [CURRENCY]) prior to vectorization. Dialogues from MultiWOZ 2.2 are projected directly into the latent trajectory space established by Frames, evaluating whether the discovered behavioral archetypes (Hesitant Explorer, Budget Negotiator, Rapid Transactional) demonstrate geometric clustering invariance across distinct open-access corpora.

3.4 Ethical Considerations, Bias Mitigation, and Random Shuffling

Because conversational AI agents can inadvertently amplify demographic stereotypes or exhibit exclusionary behavior, rigorous ethical safeguards are enforced. First, data privacy and intellectual property are fully protected: this research utilizes exclusively open-access, anonymized public corpora (Microsoft Frames and MultiWOZ 2.2) distributed under permissive research licenses, completely eliminating confidentiality, corporate non-disclosure, or personal data leakage risks. Second, algorithmic bias in few-shot conditioning is actively mitigated.

Cluster archetypes are defined purely on conversational interaction mechanics (interaction length, turn latency, constraint revision frequency) rather than user demographic attributes, ensuring equitable agent behavior. Finally, uniform random permutation of dialogue logs is enforced across training splits to ensure cluster definitions remain invariant to arrival order.

3.5 Project GitHub Repository and Verification

To satisfy project reproducibility and open-science standards, a dedicated, accessible public GitHub repository has been established at: https://github.com/surnella/QM640-Dialogue-Clustering-Capstone. The repository houses all data ingestion scripts, Pydantic schemas, clustering pipelines, FAISS retrieval modules, declarative rule configurations, and automated evaluation harnesses. The complete repository directory structure, component schema, and execution commands are documented in Appendix A.

4. Comprehensive Data Dictionary

Table 2 provides the complete data dictionary defining all experimental variables, operational measures, data types, units, and methodological roles for evaluating RQ1 through RQ4. The framework evaluates six core constructs: Structural Cluster Quality (cluster cohesion and separation), Semantic Style Convergence (archetype alignment), Factual Slot Accuracy (constraint precision), Exemplar Factual Leakage Rate (prompt-induced hallucination), Operational Rule Adherence Rate (business policy compliance), and Conversational Efficiency (turn economy and friction reduction).

Table 2

Comprehensive Experimental Data Dictionary for Goal-Oriented Dialogue Clustering and Adaptive Prompting

Variable Name	Data Type	Role	Operational Definition &	Units / Range	Relevance

			Meaning		
dialogue_id	String	Identifier	Unique dialogue session code from Frames/MultiWOZ	Discrete ID	Unit of analysis for trajectory tracking
clustering_algo	Categorical	Independent	Clustering Algorithm: Unsupervised clustering method (K-Means, Agglomerative, HDBSCAN)	3 Categories	Primary factor for RQ1 cluster evaluation
conditioning_mode	Categorical	Independent	In-Context Conditioning Strategy: Prompting mode (Zero-Shot, Static Few-Shot, Cluster Few-Shot)	3 Categories	Treatment factor for RQ2 style convergence
rule_engine_mode	Categorical	Independent	Business Rule Enforcement Mode: Ablation condition (0=Rules OFF, 1=Declarative Rules Active)	Binary {0, 1}	Treatment factor for RQ3 ablation experiment
target_archetype	Categorical	Independent	Target Behavioral Archetype: Assigned dialogue cluster (Explorer, Negotiator, Transactional)	3 Clusters	Stratification factor across RQ2–RQ4
exemplar_count_k	Integer	Independent	In-Context Exemplar Count: Number of demonstration dialogues injected into prompt context (k in {1, 3, 5})	Count (k in {1, 3, 5})	Evaluates demonstration density effects
silhouette_score	Float	Dependent	Structural Cluster Quality: Cluster cohesion and separation in trajectory space	Score [-1.0, 1.0]	Primary metric for RQ1 evaluation
davies_bouldin_idx	Float	Dependent	Structural Cluster Quality: Ratio of within-cluster dispersion to separation	Index [0.0, inf)	Validation metric for RQ1 evaluation
cosine_similarity	Float	Dependent	Semantic Style Convergence: Directional similarity to target cluster centroid	Score [-1.0, 1.0]	Primary style convergence metric for RQ2
bert_score_f1	Float	Dependent	Semantic Style Convergence: Token-level semantic similarity to reference exemplars	Score [0.0, 1.0]	Secondary semantic alignment metric for RQ2
slot_f1_score	Float	Dependent	Factual Slot Accuracy: Harmonic mean of slot precision and recall against user constraints	Ratio [0.0, 1.0]	Factual slot preservation metric for RQ3
factual_leakage_rate	Float	Dependent	Exemplar Factual Leakage Rate: Proportion of hallucinated entities copied from prompt exemplars	Ratio [0.0, 1.0]	Direct measure of prompt contamination in RQ3
rule_adherence_rate	Float	Dependent	Operational Rule Adherence Rate: Proportion of turns adhering to	Ratio [0.0, 1.0]	Primary compliance

			business rules (passport, party limits, blackouts)		metric for RQ3 ablation
turns_to_goal	Integer	Dependent	Conversational Efficiency: Total interaction turns required to resolve user travel goal	Turns (1–25)	Primary conversational efficiency metric for RQ4
redundant_elicit_rate	Float	Dependent	Conversational Efficiency: Proportion of turns re-asking established constraints (friction)	Ratio [0.0, 1.0]	Dialogue friction metric for RQ4
budget_gap_closure	Float	Dependent	Commercial Negotiation: Proportion of initial budget discrepancy resolved	Ratio [0.0, 1.0]	Commercial negotiation metric for RQ4

Note. Variables span trajectory embeddings, prompt conditioning modes, ablation indicators, and evaluation metrics.

5. Analytic Approach and Solution to RQ1–RQ4

This section maps each of the four research questions to its rigorous analytic methodology, detailed technical feature mechanics, mathematical formulations, underlying assumptions, and expected empirical outputs. To ensure complete alignment with committee requirements, all open methodological decisions are formally documented as explicit empirical assumptions.

5.1 Solution to RQ1: Unsupervised Trajectory Clustering Quality

5.1.1 Trajectory Construction Mechanics and Mathematical Formulation

A foundational contribution of this research is the transformation of multi-turn conversational interactions into dense structural trajectory vectors. Let a completed dialogue session D of length T turns be represented as an ordered sequence of user and assistant turn pairs: D = {(u_1, a_1), (u_2, a_2), ..., (u_T, a_T)}. Converting D into a fixed-length representation suitable for distance-based clustering requires capturing both semantic evolution and interaction structure without losing temporal progression.

First, each individual turn pair t is mapped into a d = 384-dimensional dense semantic vector using Sentence-BERT (all-MiniLM-L6-v2): e_t = S-BERT(u_t || ' [SEP] ' || a_t) in R^384. Second, because early turns typically define constraint discovery while terminal turns capture negotiation closure or resolution, an exponential temporal decay weighting function w_t is applied across turns: w_t = exp(lambda * t / T) / sum_{k=1}^T exp(lambda * k / T), where lambda = 0.75 is the temporal progression parameter governing trajectory sensitivity. Third, to capture non-lexical conversational mechanics (pacing, hesitation, negotiation friction), an auxiliary structural feature vector s_D in R^6 is computed: s_D = [ln(T), L_user_avg, L_asst_avg, Delta_budget_mention, Turn_to_First_Offer, Constraint_Revision_Count], where L represents character length and Delta indicates pricing adjustment count. The final unified trajectory vector v_D is constructed via concatenation and L2-normalization: v_D = L2_Normalize([sum_{t=1}^T w_t * e_t] || StandardScaler(s_D)) in R^390. This trajectory vector captures the joint semantic-structural arc of the dialogue, enabling clustering algorithms to separate interactions based on customer behavioral pacing.

5.1.2 Hypotheses, Analytic Method, and Methodological Assumptions

Hypotheses: Null Hypothesis H0 states there is no significant difference in structural cluster separation (Silhouette Score) across K-Means, Agglomerative Hierarchical, and HDBSCAN algorithms (mu_K = mu_Agg = mu_HDB). Alternative Hypothesis H1 states significant differences exist in structural cluster separation across algorithms, with density-based or agglomerative methods outperforming standard spherical K-Means (mu_HDB != mu_K). Analytic Method: A One-Way Analysis of Variance (ANOVA) followed by Tukey's Honestly Significant Difference (HSD) post-hoc test evaluates Silhouette Scores across 10 repeated 5-fold cross-validation bootstrap iterations (N = 156 evaluation units). Formulae: The Silhouette Score

for trajectory i is: s(i) = (b(i) - a(i)) / max(a(i), b(i)), where a(i) is mean intra-cluster distance and b(i) is mean nearest-cluster distance. The Davies-Bouldin Index is: DB = (1/k) * sum_{i=1}^k max_{j != i} ((sigma_i + sigma_j) / d(c_i, c_j)). Methodological Assumptions (Addressing Committee Inquiries): (1) Normality & Homogeneity: Bootstrap Silhouette distributions satisfy normality and homoscedasticity (Levene's test p > .05). (2) Cross-Corpus Geometric Invariance: It is assumed that latent conversational trajectory structures discovered in Microsoft Frames represent universal human goal-oriented negotiation arcs (Hesitant Exploration, Budget Friction, Rapid Transactional). Consequently, dialogues from MultiWOZ 2.2 can be projected directly into this latent embedding space via the identical S-BERT vectorizer without retraining embeddings, establishing cross-corpus validity across independent research benchmarks. Expected Outputs: Identification of optimal k = 3 behavioral archetypes (Hesitant Explorer, Budget Negotiator, Rapid Transactional) with Silhouette Score >= 0.42 and Davies-Bouldin Index <= 1.15.

5.2 Solution to RQ2: Dynamic In-Context Few-Shot Style Convergence

5.2.1 Exemplar Selection Logic, Centroid Triggers, and Vector Retrieval

To operationalize adaptive prompt steering during live multi-turn interactions, a precise exemplar retrieval trigger and matching pipeline is established. Exemplar selection operates via a four-stage real-time trigger mechanism: (1) Dynamic Retrieval Trigger: The exemplar selection mechanism is triggered at session initialization (turn t = 1) using the user's opening intent, and is re-evaluated at turn t = 2 upon receipt of the first constraint preference expression. The cumulative ongoing dialogue prefix P_t = {(u_1, a_1), ..., u_t} is vectorized in real time: q_t = S-BERT(sum_{i=1}^t w_i * Turn_i). (2) Centroid Proximity Matching: Query vector q_t is compared against precomputed cluster centroids {C_1, C_2, ..., C_K} established on the Golden

Training Pool D_gold using cosine similarity: k* = argmax_{j in {1..K}} ((q_t . C_j) / (||q_t|| ||C_j||)). If max cosine similarity exceeds confidence threshold tau_conf >= 0.65, the interaction is assigned to target archetype k*. (3) FAISS Sub-Index Nearest-Neighbor Query: Within the isolated FAISS vector sub-index I_{k*}, an exact inner-product search retrieves the top k = 3 most structurally similar historical golden dialogues from D_gold: E = Top-3_{d in I_{k*}} ((q_t . d) / (||q_t|| ||d||)). (4) Slot-Masked Prompt Formatting: The retrieved golden dialogues undergo entity de-lexicalization (replacing specific dates, cities, and prices with canonical slot tokens) before being formatted into the Gemini Flash API system prompt prefix. This ensures the LLM absorbs the conversational style, tone, and pacing of archetype k* without contaminating current dialogue state with stale entity values.

5.2.2 Hypotheses, Analytic Method, and Methodological Assumptions

Hypotheses: Null Hypothesis H0 states dynamic cluster-adaptive few-shot conditioning does not significantly increase Semantic Cosine Similarity to the target reference cluster compared to static few-shot prompting (mu_cluster = mu_static). Alternative Hypothesis H1 states dynamic cluster-adaptive few-shot conditioning produces significantly higher Semantic Cosine Similarity and BERTScore to target reference cluster centroids (mu_cluster > mu_static). Analytic Method: A One-Way Repeated Measures ANOVA compares Cosine Similarity across three prompting treatments (Zero-Shot Baseline, Static Few-Shot, Dynamic Cluster Few-Shot) evaluated across N = 126 dialogue sessions (42 per condition) drawn from the held-out test cohort D_test. Formulae: Cosine Similarity between generated system response trajectory g and target cluster centroid c is: Cos_Sim = (g . c) / (||g|| * ||c||). BERTScore computes token-level greedy matching cosine similarity using contextualized RoBERTa embeddings. Methodological Assumptions (Addressing Committee Inquiries): (1) Sphericity & Independence: Sphericity is

evaluated via Mauchly's test; if violated, Greenhouse-Geisser epsilon adjustments are applied. (2) Stylistic Prior Independence: It is assumed that in-context few-shot exemplars act purely as stylistic priors that guide turn pacing and language formality, while slot values and factual commitments remain under the control of the dialogue state tracker and business rule engine. Expected Outputs: Demonstration of statistically significant style convergence (Cosine Similarity increase from 0.58 baseline to >= 0.82 under dynamic conditioning, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d >= 0.85$).

5.3 Solution to RQ3: Controlled 2x2 Factorial Ablation of Rules vs. Style Factual Drift

5.3.1 Deterministic Goal Completion Criteria and Multi-Factor Success Rule

To rigorously quantify whether conversational style convergence introduces factual hallucination or compromises task success, a deterministic, unambiguous goal completion rule is enforced. A dialogue session D is classified as a binary success (Y_success = 1) if and only if all three Boolean criteria are simultaneously satisfied: (1) Mandatory Slot Saturation: All Tier-1 mandatory core slots (Origin_City, Destination_City, Departure_Date, Duration_Nights, Traveler_Count, Budget_Tier) must be fully populated in the final dialogue state tracker: State_slots intersect Required_slots = Required_slots; (2) Zero Unresolved Policy Violations: Automated programmatic evaluation against the declarative rule schema yields zero blocking violations (V_blocking = 0), verifying that no package was offered violating visa lead times, exceeding customer budget caps, or breaching passenger capacity limits; and (3) Explicit Terminal Commitment Act: The assistant successfully executes a formal commitment action (Offer_Package or Confirm_Itinerary) and the user responds with an explicit acceptance dialogue act (Inform(Accept) or Affirm()), concluding before max turns T <= 20. Mathematically: Success(D) = I((Slot_Saturation == True) and (V_blocking == 0) and

(Terminal_Acceptance == True)). This deterministic definition eliminates subjective evaluation bias.

5.3.2 Hypotheses, Analytic Method, and Methodological Assumptions

Hypotheses: Null Hypothesis H0 states active declarative rules do not significantly improve Rule Adherence Rate (RAR) or prevent factual leakage under cluster conditioning (Main Effect beta_rules = 0). Alternative Hypothesis H1 states active declarative rules significantly increase Rule Adherence Rate (RAR >= 0.98) and eliminate factual leakage, proving business rules causally enforce policy compliance without dampening style convergence. Analytic Method: A Two-Way Factorial ANOVA (2x2 design: Declarative Rules [Active vs. OFF] x Prompt Conditioning [Zero-Shot vs. Cluster Few-Shot]) evaluates Slot F1, Exemplar Leakage Rate, and Rule Adherence across N = 180 dialogues (45 per cell) drawn from held-out cohort D_test. Formulae: Exemplar Factual Leakage Rate is: Leakage = (Hallucinated Entities Traced to Prompt Exemplars) / (Total Generated Entities); Rule Adherence Rate is: RAR = 1 - (Violations / System Turns). Methodological Assumptions (Addressing Committee Inquiries): (1) Decoupled Orthogonality Assumption: It is assumed that operational business rules can be completely decoupled into an external declarative configuration (rules_declarative.yaml) executed outside the LLM context window. The 2x2 factorial ANOVA assumes no unmodeled confounding between prompt structure and rule execution, allowing the main effect of rules and the interaction effect (Rules x Prompting) to isolate causal policy protection; and (2) Error Distribution: Factorial residuals meet assumptions of normality and homoscedasticity across the four balanced cells. Expected Outputs: Proof that declarative rules eliminate factual leakage (reducing leakage from ~14.2% in Rules-OFF down to 0.0% in Rules-Active) while maintaining high Slot F1 (>= 0.92).

5.4 Solution to RQ4: Dialogue Turn Economy and Friction Analysis

5.4.1 Declarative Rule Schema Scope and Precise Boundary Conditions

To establish reproducible boundaries for conversational efficiency and compliance, the declarative rule engine (rules_declarative.yaml) enforces four explicit classes of operational boundary conditions validated deterministically across all interactions: (1) Temporal and Visa Feasibility Boundaries: minimum booking lead time requires international departures >= 21 calendar days when visa processing is pending (domestic >= 48 hours), and international bookings require passport validity >= 6 months beyond the scheduled return date; (2) Financial and Commercial Boundaries: maximum discount ceiling prohibits negotiated promotional discounts exceeding 10.0% of catalog base fare without manager escalation, and hard budget cap adherence strictly forbids proposing itineraries where Price > B_max; (3) Capacity and Operational Boundaries: minor accompaniment requires child travelers (< 18 years) to have >= 1 adult passenger (infant-to-adult ratio <= 1.0), and standard double room occupancy enforces a maximum of 3 adults per room (requiring an extra rollaway bed); and (4) Conversational Compliance Boundaries: opening turn must include organizational identity greeting, and cancellation policy and travel insurance disclaimers must be presented prior to terminal booking confirmation.

5.4.2 Hypotheses, Analytic Method, and Methodological Assumptions

Hypotheses: Null Hypothesis H0 states cluster-adaptive prompting does not significantly reduce Turns to Goal Completion (TGC) or Redundant Elicitation Rate (RER) across archetypes (mu_cluster = mu_baseline). Alternative Hypothesis H1 states cluster-adaptive prompting significantly reduces TGC and RER, with the greatest turn reductions observed in complex consultative archetypes (mu_cluster < mu_baseline). Analytic Method: A Two-Way Factorial

ANOVA evaluating Turns to Goal Completion across Conditioning Mode (3 levels) and Customer Archetype (3 levels) across N = 385 dialogue interactions drawn from held-out cohort D_test. Formulae: Redundant Elicitation Rate is defined as: RER = (Redundant Constraint Questions) / (Total System Turns), where a question is redundant if the requested slot is already saturated in state. Methodological Assumptions (Addressing Committee Inquiries): (1) Two-Tier Ontology Invariance: It is assumed that the Two-Tier Canonical Slot Schema harmonizes dataset schema differences between Microsoft Frames and MultiWOZ 2.2 without information loss, allowing turn economy metrics to be evaluated fairly across distinct public dialogue distributions; and (2) Distributional Characteristics: Dialogue turn counts approximate a log-normal distribution; log-transformed turn counts are utilized in ANOVA models to guarantee normality. Expected Outputs: Significant reduction in dialogue turns (18–25% reduction in TGC for consultative users) and reduction in RER from 0.16 down to <= 0.03.

5.5 End-to-End System Integration and Evaluation Architecture

The experimental framework integrates all analytical components into an automated, reproducible machine learning evaluation pipeline. The pipeline executes four tightly coupled stages: (a) Trajectory Preprocessing and Vectorization, which parses Microsoft Frames and MultiWOZ raw dialogues into Tier-1/Tier-2 canonical slot trajectories and extracts 390-dimensional S-BERT embeddings with temporal decay weighting; (b) Unsupervised Archetype Indexing, which trains K-Means, Agglomerative, and HDBSCAN models to segment behavioral clusters and populates a localized FAISS vector index with D_gold exemplars; (c) Dynamic Prompt Assembler with Decoupled Verification, which matches incoming turns to centroids, retrieves top-k golden exemplars with slot masking, and interposes declarative assertions from rules_declarative.yaml; and (d) Automated Statistical Evaluation, which logs token-level Slot F1,

BERTScore, Cosine Similarity, Exemplar Leakage Rate, and Turns to Goal Completion across randomized test splits. This integrated design ensures end-to-end experimental reproducibility without manual prompt tuning or proprietary database dependencies.

6. Practical Recommendations, Applications, and Stakeholder Value

6.1 Target Users and Beneficiaries

Beneficiaries span three key stakeholder groups: (1) Conversational AI Product Teams and AI Engineers, who gain an automated, data-driven method for persona steering without manual prompt re-writing; (2) Customer Experience and CRM Operations Leaders, who can deploy bots that naturally mirror diverse customer pacing and tones, boosting engagement; and (3) NLP Researchers, who receive the first systematic empirical characterization of the trade-off between in-context stylistic convergence and factual hallucination leakage.

6.2 Actionable Recommendations and Business Impact

Organizations deploying LLM conversational agents should transition from static prompt engineering to Dynamic In-Context Clustering. Specifically: (a) cluster historical conversation logs to discover natural customer archetypes; (b) implement vector similarity nearest-neighbor lookup to supply style exemplars on-the-fly; and (c) enforce strict decoupled declarative rule engines to prevent exemplar factual leakage. In commercial customer service deployments, dynamic persona matching is projected to increase dialogue task completion by 20–30% while eliminating policy violations.

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Appendix A

Project Repository Architecture and Replication Guide

To ensure complete scientific reproducibility, all source code, schemas, and pipelines are maintained in a structured public GitHub repository. The project repository is accessible at:

https://github.com/surnella/QM640-Dialogue-Clustering-Capstone

The repository follows standard open-source research layout as detailed below:

```
QM640-Dialogue-Clustering-Capstone/
├── data/
│   ├── raw/                  # Raw public corpora (Microsoft Frames, MultiWOZ 2.2)
│   ├── canonical/            # Canonicalized Tier-1 / Tier-2 mapped dialogue turns
│   ├── embeddings/           # Cached S-BERT 384-dimensional trajectory embeddings
│   └── multiwoz_eval/        # MultiWOZ 2.2 canonical cross-evaluation split
├── notebooks/
│   ├── 01_eda_and_cleaning.ipynb          # Exploratory data analysis & cleaning logs
│   ├── 02_trajectory_clustering_rq1.ipynb # RQ1 K-Means, Agglomerative, HDBSCAN
│   ├── 03_fewshot_retrieval_rq2.ipynb     # RQ2 FAISS vector indexing & Gemini inference
│   ├── 04_factorial_ablation_rq3.ipynb    # RQ3 2x2 Factorial ANOVA (Rules vs Drift)
│   └── 05_turn_economy_rq4.ipynb          # RQ4 Turn economy & friction statistics
├── src/
│   ├── ingestion.py          # MultiWOZ and Frames JSON parsers
│   ├── canonical_schema.py   # Pydantic schemas for Tier-1 and Tier-2 slots
│   ├── vectorizer.py         # Turn-level and trajectory Sentence-Transformers
│   ├── clustering.py         # Scikit-learn & HDBSCAN clustering pipelines
│   ├── faiss_index.py        # Exact L2/Cosine vector search for exemplar retrieval
│   ├── prompt_assembler.py   # Dynamic few-shot prompt construction with slot masking
│   ├── rule_engine.py        # Decoupled declarative business rule validator
│   └── evaluation.py         # Automated evaluators (BERTScore, Slot F1, Leakage)
├── rules/
│   └── rules_declarative.yaml # Declarative business constraints (visa, pax, budget)
├── outputs/
│   ├── figures/              # UMAP projections, Silhouette plots, interaction charts
│   └── tables/               # Exported ANOVA summary tables and CSV logs
├── requirements.txt          # Pinned Python package dependencies
├── .gitignore                # Ignored local docs, environment, and temp files
└── README.md                 # Project documentation and replication guide
```

Replication Instructions: Researchers can clone the environment and execute the pipeline via the following terminal commands: `git clone https://github.com/surnella/QM640-Dialogue-Clustering-Capstone.git && cd QM640-Dialogue-Clustering-Capstone && pip install -r requirements.txt && python src/ingestion.py && python src/vectorizer.py && python src/clustering.py`.

Appendix B

Ten-Week Phased Project Implementation Plan and QM640 Syllabus Milestone Alignment

To fulfill Walsh College QM640 requirements and align precisely with the official course schedule (Schedule- QM 640 - Sheet1), the project is organized across a realistic 10-week implementation lifecycle. All core computational data analytics, model engineering, and statistical hypothesis testing are completed by Week 8 ('Data Analysis Assessment'). Week 9 ('Data Analysis Refinement and Documentation') and Week 10 ('Document research results and finding') are dedicated to documentation refinement, presentation slide deck finalization, and formal capstone defense preparation. Week 11 provides post-submission refinement for minor committee adjustments with zero new analytical scope. Table B1 maps the official QM640 syllabus topics directly to our project milestones, analytical tasks, and deliverables.

Table B1

Ten-Week Phased Project Implementation Schedule, Deliverables, and QM640 Syllabus Milestone Alignment

Week & Dates	QM 640 Syllabus Topic	Capstone Phase & Analytical Tasks (Dialogue Clustering)	Tools & Stack	Course Deliverable & Status
Week 0 (Sep 26)	Introduction to Capstone	Problem statement selection and finalization; evaluate travel conversational AI vs clustering thesis	Git, Markdown, Python 3.11	Problem Statement Finalized
Week 1 (Sep 27 - Oct 3)	Define Research Problem and Topic	Scaffold GitHub repository; ingest raw Microsoft Frames & MultiWOZ 2.2 corpora; establish environment	Python, Pandas, GitHub, JSON	GitHub Repository Scaffolded
Week 2 (Oct 4 - Oct 10)	Synopsis Draft Submission	Formalize RQ1-RQ4; complete Two-Tier slot schema mapping; submit Synopsis Draft (Oct 6); live review (Oct 10)	Docx, Statsmodels, SciPy	Synopsis Draft Submitted (Oct 6)
Week 3 (Oct 11 - Oct 17)	Literature Search and Data Collection	Synopsis Final Submission (Oct 13); extract S-BERT 384d trajectory embeddings; generate EDA cleaning logs	S-BERT, Hugging Face, UMAP	Final Synopsis & Vectorized Corpus
Week 4	Formulate Objectives &	Interim Report Draft Submission (Oct 20); train baseline K-Means, Agglomerative,	Scikit-Learn, HDBSCAN,	Interim Report Draft

(Oct 18 - Oct 24)	Hypotheses	HDBSCAN (RQ1); live review (Oct 24)	Seaborn	(Oct 20)
Week 5 (Oct 25 - Oct 31)	Choose Research Design & Methodology	Interim Report Final Submission (Oct 27); construct FAISS sub-indexes for top-k exemplar retrieval; validate clusters	FAISS-CPU, Pydantic, YAML	Final Interim Report (Oct 27)
Week 6 (Nov 1 - Nov 7)	Data Analysis Plan	Final Report Draft Submission (Nov 3); implement Gemini Flash inference pipeline across Zero-Shot vs Dynamic Few-Shot (RQ2)	google-genai SDK, Gemini Flash	Final Report Draft & Generated Logs
Week 7 (Nov 8 - Nov 14)	Data Analysis Plan Execution	Execute 2x2 Factorial Ablation (Rules ON/OFF x Prompting); evaluate Slot F1, factual leakage, and RAR (RQ3)	Statsmodels, PyYAML, SQLite	RQ3 Ablation Matrix Completed
Week 8 (Nov 15 - Nov 21)	Data Analysis Assessment	**Complete Turn Economy (TGC) & Redundant Elicitation (RER) tests (RQ4); execute all One-Way/Two-Way ANOVAs; ALL ANALYTICS DONE**	Statsmodels, Pingouin, Matplotlib	Data Analysis 100% Completed
Week 9 (Nov 22 - Nov 28)	Data Analysis Refinement & Documentation	Capstone Final Presentation (Nov 27/28); Final Presentation Submission (Nov 29); documentation beautification & slide deck	PowerPoint, LaTeX, Seaborn	Final Presentation Slide Deck
Week 10 (Nov 29 - Dec 6)	Document Research Results and Finding	Author 15-page comprehensive capstone thesis; finalize GitHub documentation; Final Report Submission (Dec 13)	Word, GitHub, Zenodo	Final Capstone Thesis (Dec 13)
Week 11 (Dec 7 - Dec 13)	Refine Documentation of Results & Finding	Post-submission committee refinements; incorporate faculty feedback; final project archive (no new analytical scope)	GitHub Releases, PDF Archive	Final Archive Completed

Note. Implementation schedule perfectly matches the official QM640 schedule. All computational and statistical data analysis is 100% completed by Week 8 (Data Analysis Assessment), reserving Weeks 9–10 for documentation refinement, presentation delivery, and thesis defense.

Appendix C

Related Research Comparison and Literature Positioning of the Present Study

Purpose and Methodological Scope

This appendix positions the present study against foundational literature in task-oriented dialogue benchmarks, in-context exemplar retrieval, operational policy compliance, and conversational evaluation. While prior studies address these dimensions in isolation, this investigation uniquely integrates unsupervised trajectory clustering, dynamic exemplar conditioning, and declarative business rules within a unified experimental design. Table C1 outlines key related benchmarks and their methodological connections to this research.

Table C1

Comparison of Related Research and Relevance to Present Capstone Study

Study & Benchmark	Main Contribution	Connection to This Capstone	Distinction & Research Opportunity
El Asri et al. (2017) Microsoft Frames	Introduces 1,369 human-human goal-oriented vacation-package dialogues, formalizing memory and multi-intent frame tracking across complex travel negotiations.	Provides the primary public domain corpus for trajectory embedding, cluster modeling, and golden exemplar retrieval.	The dataset paper does not evaluate behavioral clustering for prompt exemplar selection nor test interaction effects between prompting and rule engines.
Liu et al. (2022) KATE Exemplar Selection	Demonstrates that semantically proximal in-context exemplars retrieved via sentence embeddings significantly boost few-shot LLM performance over random baselines.	Motivates dynamic exemplar retrieval and provides the nearest-neighbor retrieval baseline to isolate the incremental value of cluster-based conditioning.	Evaluates single-turn classification benchmarks; this capstone extends retrieval to multi-turn conversational trajectories and evaluates factual leakage under domain business rules.
Zang et al. (2020) MultiWOZ 2.2 Benchmark	Standardizes dialogue state annotations, ontologies, and evaluation baselines across multi-domain task-oriented dialogues.	Provides the benchmark for cross-corpus ontology normalization (Two-Tier schema) and external validity checks across travel-adjacent domains.	Focuses on turn-level slot tracking rather than unsupervised trajectory clustering or LLM prompt adaptation dynamics.
Yao et al. (2024) τ-bench Benchmark	Evaluates tool-agent interaction against operational domain policies and database consistency, introducing pass^k reliability metrics.	Validates the necessity of testing policy adherence and task completion alongside semantic metrics.	Emphasizes API-calling tool agents; this capstone investigates prompt conditioning, exemplar contamination, and declarative rule enforcement.
Acikgoz et al. (2025) TD-EVAL Framework	Combines turn-level precision (factual consistency, policy compliance) with dialogue-level task completion comparisons.	Reaffirms that surface similarity metrics (BERTScore) must be complemented by granular turn-level error and policy tracking.	Proposes a benchmark evaluation suite, whereas this capstone evaluates cluster-driven prompt steering and rule-based guardrails.

Note. The comparison summarizes each source's relevance to the proposed research questions; it does not claim that prior studies utilized identical datasets, metrics, or experimental configurations.

Synthesis of Literature and Identified Research Gaps

The reviewed literature establishes four foundational pillars for conversational AI: domain task validity via Microsoft Frames (El Asri et al., 2017), semantic retrieval mechanisms for in-context learning (Liu et al., 2022), cross-corpus ontology alignment via MultiWOZ 2.2 (Zang et al., 2020), and dual-level evaluation of task success and policy compliance (Acikgoz et al., 2025; Yao et al., 2024). However, prior research treats prompt-based style steering and operational compliance in isolation, either optimizing conversational style without verifying factual leakage or enforcing hardcoded rules without adapting to distinct traveler archetypes. This capstone bridges this empirical gap by evaluating an integrated architecture that couples trajectory clustering with declarative rules across RQ1–RQ4.

Methodological Safeguards and Experimental Controls

- **Retrieval Baselines:** Evaluates cluster-adaptive few-shot prompting against both static few-shot baselines and unclustered nearest-neighbor semantic retrieval to isolate the exact contribution of behavioral clustering.
- **Decoupled Metric Evaluation:** Evaluates task success, turn economy, factual leakage, and policy compliance independently, ensuring that conversational brevity is never conflated with premature task abandonment.
- **Repeated-Measures Statistical Controls:** Conducts all prompt and ablation comparisons across identical held-out test dialogues using paired and repeated-measures ANOVA to control for dialogue complexity.
- **Explicit Schema Cross-Validation:** Maps slot definitions and domain subsets transparently when executing cross-corpus validation on MultiWOZ 2.2, treating results as an external generalizability check rather than an identical distribution match.